

Do girls have a (moral) right to compete in sporting contests that exclude boys?

Introduction

Jackie Joyner Kersee, the six-time Olympic track and field gold medalist, said: “Girls playing sports is not about winning gold medals. It’s about self-esteem, learning to compete, and learning how hard you have to work in order to achieve your goals.” I would agree and add to her sentiments: girls have a moral right to compete in activities such as sporting contests that both include and exclude boys.

This essay will begin by exploring the historical context and gender bias in sports. It will discuss the differences in reward criteria and physical capabilities between male and female athletes, emphasizing the inherent challenges women face in co-ed competitions. By examining the factors that influence participation rates and the importance of equitable sports education and training, I will argue for the necessity of maintaining separate competitions for girls to ensure fairness and opportunity. Finally, I will endorse the moral right of girls to compete in sports that exclude boys and consider the broader implications of gender equality in sports.

Historical Context and Gender Bias in Sports

The historical bias towards women continues to influence the proportion of women who participate in different sports. When the very first Olympic Games were held in ancient Greece, women’s social status disallowed them from participating in all contests (Pausanias 5.6.8ff.). At that time, only men were allowed to participate in sports, as men were socially and culturally considered to be brave and strong, whereas women were seen as delicate.

As a figure skater, I have often witnessed the tenacity and resilience of girls in their training. When they fall, most immediately stand up and continue practicing, never complaining about the hardships of training. The strength I’ve seen in women is more of a pliable beauty, rather than posturing of heavy confrontation during competition. Such figure skating rule-making and evaluations included in this latter phenomena of competitive competitions, however, encourage me to ponder the intriguing question: why has such a phenomenon occurred? In figure skating competitions, women are only allowed to do triple jumps in a short program while men can do quadruple jumps. If women were to compete directly with men, the higher scoring male athletes would dominate, leading to an unfair competition.

Differences in Reward Criteria and Physical Capabilities

In competition, female skaters are rewarded for qualities such as grace, beauty, and lightness, while male skaters are applauded more for such demonstrations of strength, power, and force (Adams, 2011). Males tend to jump higher or perform stronger jumps, and even more quickly. Additionally, female skaters face more extreme body pressures than male skaters, who enjoy greater physical advantages in the sport. Men

and women differ in their hormones; boys and girls even enter puberty at different times, meaning men and women may have congenital differences without any sports training. As women are usually smaller in height and have a higher percentage of body fat, which disadvantages them in track and field. While women are more flexible than men, most men are stronger than women, allowing male athletes to perform difficult movements that women cannot, and thus scoring higher in competitions. Sex is indeed a major factor influencing best performances and world records (Thibault.V, 2010).

Progress in Gender Equality in Sports

Significant progress has been made to eliminate bias towards women during human society's development: women eventually began attending sports games and competitions; the number of events and participants in competitions then gradually increased; as one milestone, the proportion of female athletes in the 1976 Olympics Games exceeded 20 percent for the first time; the number of female players in the 2008 Beijing Olympic Games then reached 4,540, accounting for 42.4 percent; the 2012 London Olympic Games achieved a "double first", where women participated in all sports (women's boxing had entered the Olympic Games), and all participating delegations included women for the first time. From the perspective of the Olympic program setup, female athletes could participate in few events at the second Olympic Games. Sports previously considered "harmful" to women's physical and mental health were gradually been introduced into the women's Olympic program, highlighted by rowing (1976), hockey (1980), judo (1992), football (1996), weightlifting and triathlon (2000), wrestling (2004), and boxing (2012). The definition of gender began to blur in sporting events. More importantly, whether any sport fits a person or not shouldn't be gender dependent.

A total of 2,892 athletes participated in the 2022 Beijing Winter Olympics, encompassing 1,314 female athletes, and at 45.44 percent, being a record high number of female athletes participating in a Winter Olympics. With 109 events set up in that Winter Olympics, female athletes participated in 46 events, also a record compared to previous Winter Olympics.

This brings us to Paris 2024, where there will be a 1:1 ratio of men to women among the 10,500 athletes competing, with exactly 5,250 men and 5,250 women competing together. This marks the first time in Olympic history that the number of men and women participating in the Games is equal. Perhaps this equal number of male and female participants in the competitions is coincidental, and true gender equality certainly extends beyond mere headcounts. Superficial equality can still mask deeper issues. More women are competing and in more sports in the Olympics.

Challenges in Achieving True Gender Equality in Sports

Societal gender ratios are never exactly 1:1, and they vary across different countries. Even if the ratio of athlete attendance is 1:1 in a particular sporting event, it doesn't mean there is an equal number of men and women participating from each country. Moreover, the specific matches included this year do not mean the gender ratio will

be equal across every country, nor in every future year, nor in every match. Also, because gender ratios of sports events are not 1:1, the gender ratios of different sports events vary, with some sports having a higher male participation rate, and requiring preliminary rounds, semi-finals, and finals. Some sports have considerable female participation, but often in smaller numbers. Third, because the selection ratios of male and female athletes in sports events are also not 1:1, many sports enjoy a higher male participation coverage rate, with male athlete participants often selected from thousands of people. Some sports have very low female participation coverage rates. Especially if we consider the factor of regional development, sports education and training resources vary across regions. Some sports are limited by family economic conditions, coach staffing, and field conditions in underdeveloped areas, leading to high gender participation ratio gaps between regions. Across cities, suburbs, and rural areas, children have unequal access to high-tech equipment for training, coaches, and sports resources. People from different regions simply receive different levels of training. Therefore, athletes with different economic conditions and training conditions can not reflect fairness in the same competition.

Promoting Gender Equality in Sports

By conducting scientific analysis on the participation data of male and female athletes in various sports, measures such as increase in funding can improve female participation rates. Equitable and inclusive sports education and training are also essential prerequisites for promoting gender equality in sports competitions, especially for competitions requiring early-stage sports training: with a lack of early-stage scientific training, there will be much fewer chances for girls to participate in sports competitions in later and higher-level stages.

We cannot conclude that the pure numbers of men and women athletes will later become equal participation rates in future competitions. According to Jane English, equal opportunity is identified with nondiscrimination, and so sports should be more sex-blind. As sports provide basic benefits for society, both men and women should get equal chances to participate in sports games and enjoy the basic benefit sports bring.

Even if we aim to achieve equal representation of men and women in future sports competitions, with equal proportion in event participation, and equal selection criteria and coverage ratios, true fairness in sports competitions cannot be solely achieved based on gender equality. Sex is a factor frequently used to form separate competition groups, and ensuing competition classes are based on clear-cut physiological characteristics, such as weight, height, age and sex.

In addition to the inherent physiological characteristics of weight, age and sex, acquired technical ability through training is another perhaps more significant factor to consider (English, 272). Some sports competitions distinguish simply between professional and amateur groups, and in professional competitions, grouping men and women separately may promote greater equity overall; however, in amateur competitions there can begin to be more emphasis on inclusive participation with

sex-blindness. Grouping individuals by ability alone can serve as a different method to give disadvantaged people more equal access to the basic benefits of sport.

According to Jane English, she believes everyone has an equal right to attain the basic health and recreation benefits that sports provide. A society which also invents alternative sports using women's distinctive abilities, and which rewards these equally, is preferable to a society which only maintains protected classes for women in sports in which men have been and continue to be advantaged. Groupings by ability are much easier to justify than groupings by the aforementioned characteristics. There need be no discrimination against less able members of the dominant group, as ability groupings consider all the traits that may affect performance (274).

There are seemingly concrete biological differences between male and female performance that affirmative action and raising consciousness may never change. A just society, in Jane English's view, would contain a greater variety of sports than we currently have, providing advantages for a wider range of physical types. In cases where playing styles or strength differ, teams could be grouped by weight, age, or gender, but goals could expand to equally benefit everyone more with these basic benefits of health, teamwork, and fun. Girls should have opportunities to play both inclusive and separated competitions.

Gender-segregated sports increases fairness. On average, biological differences between boys and girls' development during puberty lead to disparities in strength, speed, and endurance. Separating competitions allows girls to compete on a more level playing field and be recognized for their achievements.

Additionally, gender-segregated sports also creates opportunity and encouragement. Girls-only sports provide opportunities for girls to participate without feeling discouraged by potentially stronger male competitors. This can foster a love of sports and encourage continued participation for many girls.

Gender-segregated sports are also important for identity and community. Girls-only sports can create spaces where girls feel comfortable developing their skills and a sense of belonging within a supportive team environment.

Biology, of course isn't the only factor in performance or competitiveness. Skills, training, and dedication all play major roles. Additionally, it must be recognized that sex isn't always a binary classification, and transgender athletes raise complex questions about what true inclusion is. Focusing in on inclusion, some are arguing for mixed-gender competitions, and creating categories based on more nuanced factors like performance instead of sex. Such adaptations could promote greater inclusivity while acknowledging physical differences.

Conclusion

We can improve the chances for everyone to take part in sports activities or games according to their own needs and the benefits they stand to gain and enjoy. On July 20, 2021, the International Olympic Committee approved a change in the Olympic motto, adding the word “together” to "Faster, Higher, Stronger," recognizing the unifying power of sport and the importance of solidarity.

From international to domestic competitions, the participation of men and women in sports has been recognized on the legal level across the world as a basic human right. In line with John Locke's philosophy, it is essential for government to protect individual freedoms in order to maintain a just society. Thus, girls maintain the moral right to compete in sporting contests and activities that exclude boys, even as progressive inter-gender competitions arise across sports. Girls have the right to autonomously showcase their strengths, and this right can depend on the opportunity to compete in gender-specific contests.

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